

RARE BIRD REPORT--SIGHT RECORD

REPORT FILED BY: Alan E. Versaw
403 Maplewood Drive
Colorado Springs, CO 80907 (719)266-5065

7-0 (A)

Rec'd 12/13/00 wpe

SPECIES: Bay-breasted Warbler

DATE(S): 05/14/00

OF BIRDS SEEN: 1 SEX: Male PLUMAGE: Adult breeding

LATILONG: 19 ELEVATION: uncertain, probably 5600-5800 ft.

TIME OF DAY: 1500 LOCALITY: Fountain Creek Regional Park, across trail from north gazebo

NEAREST TOWN: Fountain COUNTY: El Paso

DURATION OF OBSERVATION: approximately one minute

OTHER OBSERVERS: none

LIGHT CONDITIONS: overcast, not particularly bright for the time of day

OPTICAL EQUIPMENT: Bushnell 8 X 42 Natureviews

DISTANCE: 15-25 feet

PHOTO DATA: sorry, none

BIRD BEHAVIOR: The bird was foraging, mostly by short hops along a branch more horizontal than vertical in orientation. When the bird dropped from the branch, I lost view of the bird and could not relocate it among the 20 or so Yellow-rumped Warblers in the same general vicinity.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF BIRD: My views of the bird were from a vantage point mostly beneath the bird. Very dark head and eye (I did not note the deep chestnut-colored cap this bird should have—just that the head was very dark—I'm not sure if not noting the cap had more to do with light conditions or my angle of view). Most notable was the deep reddish-orange color of the throat, upper chest, and flanks. The border of this coloration on the flanks was not at all even. In the belly, and going up to a point in the chest, the color of the bird was a warm, creamy off-white. Undertail coverts roughly the same color as the belly. Two wing bars on dark wings. A very prominent light colored patch on the side of the neck—stood out very well against dark color of head and upper back. From my vantage point, this buffy patch appeared to go over the top of the bird, but I discovered later—when consulting the references—that the mark doesn't actually do that. That's all I could make mental note of in the brief time that I saw the bird.

SONG AND/OR CALL: None given.

HABITAT DESCRIPTION: The bird was found in a line of cottonwood and elm trees (I think both tree types are present, but I didn't really think about the precise habitat composition of this area until I was back to my car) between the regional park trail and Fountain Creek itself. On the other side of the trail is a gazebo and a slope, dominated by smallish elms, going down to some ponds.

ELIMINATION OF SIMILAR SPECIES: I know you're never supposed to say this on a rare bird report, but there just aren't many species that look a lot like a male Bay-breasted Warbler in breeding plumage. On a very crass level, a Cliff Swallow wears similar colors in a different arrangement, but I have yet to see a Cliff Swallow foraging warbler-style in a tree. Among warblers, the Chestnut-sided Warbler has similar colors in the flanks, but has a white throat and an enormous white ear patch. I'm not sure I could have seen the yellow cap of a CSWA from my angle, though. A Spotted Towhee (we're really reaching now) has spots on its wings and no wingbars and, perhaps most importantly, is both significantly bigger than Yellow-rumped Warblers (if it ever keeps company with same) and has no buffy-colored patch on the side of its neck.

PRIOR EXPERIENCE WITH THIS AND SIMILAR BIRDS: I've seen CSWAs several times. My only previous experience with Bay-breasted Warblers was last summer (1999) in Maine. Obviously, this handsome little bird made quite an impression on me because I instantly recognized this bird as the same one I saw last summer.

REFERENCES CONSULTED: None in field (no time). Later I looked at Dunn and Garrett and Natl. Geo, 3rd edition. Neither did much to add strength to or cast doubt on the ID.

DATE OF REPORT: 05/15/00

SIGNATURE: Alan Versaw